



文 35 languages

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Diction (**Latin:** *dictionem* (nom. *dictio*), "a saying, expression, word"),^[1] in its original meaning, is a writer's or speaker's distinctive **vocabulary** choices and style of expression in a piece of writing such as a poem or story.^{[2][3]} In its common meaning, it is the distinctiveness of **speech**:^{[3][4][5]} the art of speaking so that each word is clearly heard and understood to its fullest complexity and extremity, and concerns **pronunciation** and tone, rather than word choice and style. This is more precisely and commonly expressed with the term **enunciation** or with its synonym, **articulation**.^[6]

Aristotle, in *The Poetics* (20), defines the parts of diction (λέξις)^[7] as the **letter**, the **syllable**, the **conjunction**, the **article**, the **noun**, the **verb**, the **case**, and the **speech** (λόγος),^[8] though one commentator remarks that "the text is so confused and some of the words have such a variety of meanings that one cannot always be certain what the Greek says, much less what Aristotle means."^[9]

Diction is usually judged in reference to the prevailing standards of proper writing and speech and is seen as the mark of quality of the writing. It is also understood as the selection of certain words or phrases that become peculiar to a writer or character.^[10]

Certain writers in the modern day and age use archaic terms such as "thy", "thee", and "wherefore" to imbue a Shakespearean mood to their work.

Forms of diction include: archaic diction (diction that is antique, that is rarely used), high diction (lofty sounding language), and low diction (everyday language). Each of these forms is meant to enhance the meaning or artistry of an author's work.

- Action (philosophy)
- Description
- Elocution
- Greeting
- Orthoepy
- Poetic diction
- Register (sociolinguistics)
- Speech production
- Vocal pedagogy

Citations [\[edit \]](#)

1. ^ ["Diction"](#) Archived 2011-09-15 at the Wayback Machine, *Online Etymology Dictionary*
2. ^ ["diction"](#) . Merriam-Webster.com Dictionary. Springfield, Mass.: Merriam-Webster. Retrieved 24 March 2020.
3. ^ ^{***a***} ^{***b***} Crannell (1997) *Glossary*, p. 406
4. ^ *Littre - Diction*.
5. ^ Georges Le Roy, *Traité pratique de la diction française*, 1911.
6. ^ Crannell (1997) Part II, Speech, p. 84
7. ^ *The Cambridge Greek Lexicon*. Cambridge University Press. 2021. p. 865. ISBN 978110-8836982.
8. ^ Barnes, Jonathan, ed. (1984). *The Complete Works of Aristotle: The Revised Oxford Translation*. Vol. 2. Princeton University Press. p. 2331.
9. ^ Preston H. Epps. (1967). *The Poetics of Aristotle: A translation and Commentary* . Univ. of North Carolina Press. ISBN 978-0807840177. Archived from the original on 2004-06-07.
10. ^ ["What is Diction in Literature?"](#) . Oregon State Guide to Literary Terms. 5 November 2024.

- Crannell, Kenneth C. (1999) [1997]. *Voice and Articulation* (3rd ed.). Belmont: Wadsworth Publishing Company. ISBN 9780534508999. OCLC 34640688 [↗](#). *Voice and Articulation* [↗](#) at [Google Books](#) (preview of 1997 edition)
- "diction" [↗](#). Literary-Devices.com. Retrieved 24 March 2020.

- Examples of diction in poetry [↗](#)^[*usurped*]
- [Style and Diction](#) [↗](#)—free software by the [GNU Project](#)
- [Diction Översättningsbyrå](#) [↗](#)

Categories: Descriptive technique | Phonetics | Poetics | Style (fiction)


